Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Pricing Strategy

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

Seranai · March 2026

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What Is This Skill?

The Startup Pricing Strategy skill is an AI-powered tool that helps you answer one of the most consequential questions any founder faces: what should I charge, and what should I charge *for*? Most founders treat pricing as the last step. This skill reverses that.

It works as a conversation. You describe your product, your buyer, your funding situation, and where you are in the journey — and the skill guides you step by step through diagnosing your pricing problem, choosing the right model, validating a price range with real research methods, and building a tier structure that converts. No spreadsheets. No guesswork.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE
Pricing should be figured out before you build — not after. If you don't know what someone will pay before you build, you're guessing at what to build. — Ramanujam, Monetizing Innovation

By the end of one conversation (about 20 minutes), you will have a clear pricing model recommendation, a validated price range, a draft tier structure if relevant, a 30-day action plan, and an honest diagnosis of where your current pricing may be hurting you.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for founders who need to make a pricing decision — whether they're pre-launch, post-launch, or actively struggling with pricing that isn't working. It is especially useful if:

- You're pre-launch and need a starting price hypothesis before you talk to your first customers
- You have customers but sense your pricing is wrong and can't articulate why
- You're moving from founder-led sales to a repeatable process and need cleaner pricing
- You're building tiers for the first time and don't know where to start
- You're bootstrapped and need to price for profitability, not growth at all costs
- You're funded and want to charge what the market will actually bear
- You've been undercharging out of fear and want to fix it
- You're building in an emerging market and need a framework that works without US benchmarks

This skill works for any B2B product. Whether you're in Lagos, Bangalore, Dubai, São Paulo, or San Francisco — the methodology adapts to your context.

How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Startup Pricing skill installed, and your situation described in your own words.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That's it.

Step 2: Describe Your Situation

Tell Claude what your product does, who your buyer is, what you're currently charging (or thinking of charging), and whether you're bootstrapped or funded. You don't need perfect information to start — rough estimates and honest uncertainty are explicitly encouraged. The skill will ask follow-up questions for anything that's missing.

Examples of Great Starting Messages:

EXAMPLE 1 — Detailed

"I'm building a compliance monitoring SaaS for fintech startups in Southeast Asia. My buyers are CTOs and compliance officers at Series A fintechs. I'm thinking of charging $800/month per account. We're bootstrapped with 3 paying pilots."

EXAMPLE 2 — Brief

"Invoice management tool for freelance designers in India. Thinking ₹1,500/month. Not sure if per seat or flat fee."

EXAMPLE 3 — Minimal

"Inventory management for small grocery stores in Nigeria. No idea what to charge."

All three will work. The more detail you provide, the faster you'll reach a recommendation. But even a single sentence is enough — the skill will only ask for what's genuinely missing.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill guides you through four phases. You don't need to prepare anything in advance or remember any steps. Just respond naturally to the questions it asks. The whole process takes about 20 minutes.

What Happens: The Four Phases

The skill walks you through four phases, each building on the last. Here's what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 1:PRICING SNAPSHOT Instant diagnosis • ~3 minutes	
What You Do	• Describe your product in one sentence • Share your current price (or what you're thinking of charging) • Mention your funding status — bootstrapped or funded
What You Get	• A diagnosis of which of the four pricing failure modes you're most at risk for • An immediate assessment of your value metric — what you're charging for, and whether it's right • A first-pass pricing model recommendation with a one-line rationale

WHY THIS MATTERS:

The skill never asks for information you've already provided. If your price, buyer, or funding status appears anywhere in the conversation, it carries that forward without asking again. You'll see a real output in under 3 minutes — no warm-up required.

PHASE 2:SHARPENING Filling in the gaps • ~3 minutes	
What You Do	• Answer 3–5 targeted questions about your buyer, product value, current situation, and pricing goal • All questions in a single message — never dripped one at a time
What You Get	• Confirmed understanding of your buyer, their outcomes, and their willingness to pay • Clarity on your primary pricing goal: maximize revenue, grow users fast, or start high and lower over time • Identification of whether your product has a natural usage unit worth charging against

PHASE 3:FULL RECOMMENDATION Real numbers • ~8 minutes	
What You Do	• Review the pricing goal assignment and confirm it's right • Confirm or provide your product's natural value unit if one exists • Approve the Van Westendorp questions to run with your customers if you haven't done pricing research

What You Get	• A confirmed pricing model with pros, cons, and watch-outs specific to your product • A specific price range recommendation — a real number, not a hedge • A draft 3-tier structure with names, audiences, inclusions, and prices (if tiers apply) • A 5-dimension Pricing Scorecard rating your current approach

PHASE 4:ACTION PLAN What to do next • ~5 minutes to read	
What You Do	• Review the 30-day action plan and flag anything that doesn't fit your timeline or constraints
What You Get	• A week-by-week 30-day pricing action plan: validate, launch, watch, learn • Kill signals — 5 specific indicators that your price or model is wrong • The standard playbook for raising prices on existing customers without losing them • A reminder of the most important rule in pricing: your first price is a hypothesis, not a decision

Understanding Your Results

The Four Pricing Failure Modes

Before giving you a recommendation, the skill diagnoses which of four failure modes you're most at risk for. Understanding these helps you interpret the advice you receive.

FAILURE MODE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Feature Confusion	You packed in every feature and priced it as one big thing. The buyer can't figure out what they're paying for. It feels overwhelming and expensive at the same time.
Underpricing	You built something real and useful but charged almost nothing — maybe out of fear, maybe humility. In B2B, a low price makes buyers assume the product is weak. Price signals quality.
Bad Packaging	The product genuinely works. But the way it's priced or packaged buries it. Wrong structure, wrong audience, wrong tier. The product is fine — the presentation isn't.
Avoidance	Still alive, but pricing was never actually figured out — just avoided. The company runs on founder hustle. These companies look alive but the math never worked.

The Four Pricing Models

The model is how you charge — not how much. It often matters more than the actual number. The skill selects the best fit for your product, but you can always ask to explore alternatives.

MODEL	BEST WHEN…	KEY WATCH-OUT
Per Seat	Product is used by named individuals; buyers value predictability	Punishes adoption — customers think twice before adding users
Usage-Based	Product has a natural unit (API calls, transactions, messages sent)	Unpredictable monthly bill — some buyers will hate this
Tiered (Good / Better / Best)	Buyers genuinely have different needs and budgets	Breaks down when tiers are built around features you like, not needs buyers have
Base + Usage Hybrid	Larger contracts where buyers want predictability and you want growth upside	Requires clear definition of what the base includes vs. what triggers overage

The Three Pricing Goals

Your price can be trying to do one of three different things. Most founders mix them up without realising it. The skill assigns you a goal based on your situation — and all advice flows from that choice.

GOAL	WHEN IT'S RIGHT	BOOTSTRAPPED VERDICT
Maximize Revenue Per Customer	Funded or bootstrapped with a differentiated product and a clear buyer. Charge what the market will bear.	✅ Almost always correct
Grow Users Fast	Funded, product gets better with more users, clear tested path to raise prices later. Without all three, this is subsidizing customers you can't afford.	⚠️ High risk without a war chest
Start High, Lower Over Time	Creating a new category where early adopters see being first as part of the value. Capture premium buyers early, reduce price as market matures.	✅ Correct when you're genuinely first

The Van Westendorp Price Range

If you haven't done pricing research yet, the skill will give you four questions to run with 15–30 potential customers. When you map out the answers, you get a price range where most buyers are comfortable — and a sweet spot inside it.

#	QUESTION	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
1	*At what price would this feel too cheap — like you'd question if it's any good?*	Your quality floor — the minimum price that signals credibility
2	*At what price would it feel expensive, but still worth it?*	Your stretch ceiling — the maximum buyers will accept when convinced
3	*At what price would it feel too expensive to even consider?*	Your hard ceiling — pricing above this ends the conversation
4	*At what price would it feel like a bargain?*	Your sweet spot anchor — the price buyers feel good about

You'll be within 20–25% of the real answer. For an early-stage company, that's plenty good enough to make a decision and move.

Reading the Pricing Scorecard

After analyzing your situation, the skill scores your current (or proposed) pricing across five dimensions. Here's how to interpret the results:

DIMENSION	WHAT IT MEASURES	LOW SCORE MEANS…
Value Metric Alignment	Does your price scale with how much value the customer gets?	You're charging for the wrong unit — price and value are decoupled
Market Positioning	Does your price signal the right quality level for your buyer?	Underpricing (signals weakness) or overpricing (triggers dismissal)
Model-Product Fit	Does the model match how customers naturally use the product?	Friction at the point of adoption or expansion
Buyer Friction	Does pricing make it easy or hard to say yes?	Buyers are hesitating or asking to negotiate before even starting
Growth Alignment	Does pricing support long-term revenue growth as customers grow?	You're leaving expansion revenue on the table

Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Use rough numbers — that's the point.
The skill is built to work with approximations. "About 500 customers" is enough. "Around $300/month" is enough to start. You don't need precise data to get a credible recommendation — you need honest estimates you can defend.

"I don't know" moves you forward, not backward.

If you don't know your buyer's willingness to pay, the skill will give you the Van Westendorp questions to go find out. If you don't know your close rate, it will suggest a benchmark and ask if it sounds right. Uncertainty is data — it tells you what to research next.

Run it for each segment or model you're considering.

If you're deciding between per seat and usage-based, or between enterprise and SMB buyers, run a separate session for each. The contrast is often more revealing than any single recommendation.

Challenge the model recommendation.

If the skill recommends per seat and you think usage-based might work, say so. Ask it to run the usage-based version and compare. Pricing decisions benefit from seeing the alternative played out before committing.

Show the logic, not just the number.

Investors and customers don't just want to hear "$500/month." They want to understand the reasoning: what the value metric is, what comparable products charge, and what the Van Westendorp research showed. The skill's output gives you this — don't strip it out when you present.

Come back every 90 days.

Companies that revisit pricing every three months grow 2–4x faster than companies that treat it as a set-and-forget decision. Your first price is a hypothesis. The job is to test it, learn from it, and update it — not to get it perfect on the first try.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to have done the earlier skills first?

Not strictly. But your pricing recommendation will be sharper if you've already validated your problem (Skill 1) and defined your persona (Skill 4). Without knowing who your buyer is and what they urgently need, pricing becomes harder to anchor to real willingness to pay.

What if I have no idea what to charge?

That's fine and common. Describe your product and buyer, and the skill will build a price range hypothesis from comparable products, your value delivery, and the Van Westendorp method. You'll leave with a real number to test — not a shrug.

How is this different from just Googling what competitors charge?

Competitor research is one input. This skill also factors in your value metric, your buyer's psychology, your funding situation, your product's natural unit, and the structure of your tiers. A single competitor price tells you what someone else is charging. This skill tells you what *you* should charge and why.

Can I use this for B2C businesses?

The skill is optimized for B2B, where pricing, buyer personas, and willingness to pay are more clearly defined. B2C pricing — which involves consumer volume, conversion funnels, and viral dynamics — has different mechanics. A B2C-specific version is on the roadmap.

What if the skill tells me I'm underpricing?

It will tell you directly. Charging too little is not humble — in B2B, a low price makes buyers assume the product is weak. Price signals quality whether you want it to or not. The skill will show you the data behind the recommendation so you can decide whether to act on it.

What if I need to raise prices on existing customers?

The skill includes a standard playbook: give existing customers 6–12 months at their current rate before the new price kicks in, always explain the reason, and test changes on new customers first. Buyers are reasonable people — what they don't forgive is being surprised without explanation.

How long does it take?

About 20 minutes for a full pricing recommendation with a price range, model, and tier structure. Faster if you already know your buyer well and have some pricing data. Longer if you want to explore multiple models or segments in the same session.

Is my data private?

Your conversation is between you and Claude. The skill does not store or share your business details with anyone.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey.

Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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